Besides the personal loss I was yet to come to terms with, I wondered what would become of India's space programme and my experiments with liquid propulsion. I took the next flight to India. Landing in Bombay, I hesitated for a while what to do. Sarabhai's body, I knew, would be taken to Bombay on way to his hometown in Ahmedabad. I asked an airport staff if he knew about the body arriving, but he had no clue. Then I thought the body would still be in Trivandrum for an autopsy. So I took the next flight to Trivandrum. Only on reaching Trivandrum did I realise that the body was taken to Bombay soon after I left. No autopsy was conducted, apparently on the wishes of his wife Mrinalini Sarabhai. His wife, somebody said, had spoken to the Prime Minister, and the Kerala Governor P Shiv Shankar was said to have received a call from Delhi instructing him to ensure that Sarabhai's body would be handed over to the family without a scratch.

At Trivandrum airport I saw S R Thakur, Sarabhai's chief administrative officer, running towards me. He was weeping like a child. Thakur, who was Sarabhai's shadow, had accompanied him from Bombay to Trivandrum only the previous day. Thakur couldn't find place on board the plane that carried Sarabhai's body to Bombay, so here he was to take another flight for the funeral. Hugging me, Thakur sobbed. I could feel his tears wetting my shoulder.

'We came together from Bombay,' he said, 'and see, he has left alone in a body bag.'

I couldn't rush back to Bombay, and hence missed Sarabhai's funeral. About a month later, I waited at the Trivandrum airport where Sarabhai's son Kartikeya and a few others brought the ashes in an urn to be immersed at Cape Comorin, where three seas merged at the tip of the Indian peninsula. When Kartikeya, with the urn in his hand, emerged from the arrival lounge, I ran towards him. With several seniors of ISRO having lined up to receive the ash, some found this to be a disregard to protocol. I cared a damn! Sarabhai never followed the protocol when it came to getting work done—or when appreciating a work well done. In 1970, when Union Minister K C Pant visited TERLS in Trivandrum, some fifty scientists had gathered at the canteen where, on a mezzanine floor the minister sat with Sarabhai. There were scientists much senior than me in the group, but Sarabhai singled me out, and